

Every year, the achievements get better and better ►

Chairperson of the *Sportstar* Aces Awards, **Sunil Gavaskar**, calls the event the top sports awards in India.

Dndia batting great cricketer Sunil Gavaskar, chairperson of the Sportstar Aces Awards, called the annual event the crème de la crème of sports awards in the country.

"For me, what the *Sportstar* Aces Awards mean is recognition of a person's achievement, the impact he or she has had on their sport, and the legacy and example they are setting for future generations. That's why these awards are such a huge thing. There's a reason sportspeople take the time to come to this event every year. It's the crème de la crème of sporting awards in the country," Gavaskar said.

The Aces Awards is gearing up for its sixth edition, and Gavaskar is elated to see the standard of Indian sport improving each year.

"The process of choosing winners is always exciting for the simple reason that you get to see how Indian sport has progressed over the year. Every year, the achievements get better and better. Some of these milestones are staggering. The added benefit of being on this jury is being able to see other sports.

Sometimes, you're so involved in your sport or covering them on TV that you are unable to find time for other sports. This exercise helps with that. Another thing is that now we have a wider field to choose from, and that is one of the most heartening parts of the exercise," he said.

While hailing the Indian men's cricket team's run in



the ODI World Cup, Gavaskar picked Olympic javelin champion Neeraj Chopra's run in 2023 as the standout achievement.

"Neeraj is getting better and better, and that's the mark of a great athlete — one who is not satisfied with accolades and is always hungry for more. High hopes from him for Paris 2024. No pressure.

"But he will know that the country is expecting gold for the first time. All along, the nation was hoping, but this time, it's an expectation, and that's a game changer in terms of pressure. The way he took Kishore (Kumar) Jena with him [at the Asian Games 2023] put the tri-colour on their shoulders and topped that podium with gold and silver. That's a moment to cherish for a lifetime," he said.

Gavaskar revealed he is eager to meet the next set of winners and had an important message for those who

will be honoured at the Aces Awards in Mumbai in February.

"My message is, firstly, congratulations on what you've achieved. I have retired from the game for almost 40 odd years, but to see the progress that every sport has made and how a new bar is being set every year is so heartening.

"I see India becoming a sports-mad country thanks to your performances. You are setting the trend not just in one sport but across multiple disciplines. You are the torchbearers of the new generation of champions who will go on to hopefully win the *Sportstar* Aces Awards," he said.

